

Only in Florida

English 245 Fall 2018



This course takes seriously the popular perception that Florida is the nation's magnet for weird, surreal and otherwise unbelievable places, people, events and behavior. By conducting critical examinations of real-life and literary representations of alligator wrestling matches and python hunts; drug runners and dumb criminals; murder trials and Spring Break escapades, you'll gain a deeper understanding of the modes, agendas, ideologies and perspectives that inform the creation and promulgation of myth, urban legend, reputation, perception and "fact."

The structure and format of this course mirrors its content: namely, it is straight-up unconventional and downright weird. Instead of meeting for a 2.5-hour block once per week throughout the semester, we are meeting for much longer stretches of time over a much shorter period. This unique structure gives us the privilege to travel to locales and study phenomena in-depth and in-person that isn't possible within the confines of the traditional course meeting schedule.

However, with big privileges come big responsibilities. This course not only compresses a semester's worth of reading into 6 terribly short weeks, but also makes a significant demand on your time during this same period. While the course's abbreviated timeline is tantalizing in its appeal (who wouldn't want to complete a course in about half the time?), please, please, please don't be lured into the mistaken notion that a shorter course equals less work. From previous experience, most students find exactly the opposite to be true.¹ If you are able and willing to proverbially give me your weekends in September (and one in August), then this course is for you. If you have a lot on your plate at the beginning of the term, find the thought of spending long periods of time on the JUMP bus with your classmates (and me) to be less than desirable, or aren't able to commit to the class schedule, then you should jump ship while you can.

Tour Guide: Dr. Jana Mathews

¹ "This course is super fun, but it sucks up a lot of your time when it's in session. The reading load is heavy and there is no break between papers."
-from a former 'Only in Florida' student's course evaluation

Course Meets:

Sunday, August 26: 10am-3pm
Friday, August 31: 4pm until Sunday, September 2 at 6pm (overnight; Labor Day Weekend)
Sunday, September 9: 10am-3pm
Sunday, September 16: 7:30am-1:00pm
Sunday, September 23: 10am-3pm
Saturday, September 29: 9am until Sunday, September 30 at 7pm (overnight)

As noted on the course schedule, there are two overnight Immersion-based field trips: August 31-September 2 (Labor Day weekend) and September 29-30. These field trips are integral and required parts of our course and count toward the total number of contact hours included this semester. Please also note that we will be meeting from 7:45am-1pm (instead of 10-3) on September 16 to accommodate the needs of our community partner.

Office Hours: 113 Carnegie, by appointment

Email: jmathews@rollins.edu

Cell: 407-913-1679

By far the easiest and quickest way to reach me is by text. While I always aim to get back to students ASAP, texts received after 9pm may not be answered until the next morning, so hang tight and don't stress—I've got you.

Required Course Materials

Please order the three assigned texts for this course on Amazon or borrow from the library. The campus bookstore will not be selling them.

- Nilo Cruz, *Anna in the Tropics* (ISBN1559362324)
- Zora Neale Hurston, *Their Eyes Were Watching God* (ISBN 0060931418)
- Gilbert King, *The Devil in the Grove* (ISBN 0061792268)
- Access to Blackboard (BB)
- Access to Netflix and Amazon Prime Video (if you or your friends/roommates don't have one/either of these, let me know)
- Rollins email account

As noted in the course schedule, a \$100 course fee has been added to your tuition to cover the cost of field trips. Thanks to the generosity of an alum donor and the Office of Community Engagement, the remaining costs of our weekly field trips and overnight Immersions (excluding lunches) are covered.

Course Goals

- 1) to gain knowledge about the various ways that Florida literature and culture reflect broader American cultural norms and taboos
- 2) develop and hone the skill of critical analysis and close reading using literary texts, film, commercials, high and low art and architecture
- 3) to identify and conduct a critical examination of the ethical principles and issues related to Florida culture in contemporary America

Course Assignments

Your assigned work for this course will take the form of **three essays, weekly quizzes and homework assignments and on-site activities**. All essays must be double-spaced, typed in 12 point Times New Roman font and include 1-inch margins. All written work is due on Blackboard by the dates specified on the syllabus.

Please note that this course is a four-credit-hour course that meets at least 5 hours per week for 6 weeks. The value of four credit hours results from work expected of enrolled students both inside and outside the classroom. Rollins faculty require that students average about 90 minutes of outside work for every hour of scheduled class time, or about 27 hours each week, in out-of-class assignments. In this course, the additional outside-of-class expectations include assigned readings, homework assignments, take-home quizzes, group projects, essay research, writing, and revision, film screenings, community engagement activities and full participation in all weekly and overnight field studies.

Classroom Decorum

Please be respectful of your teammates and refrain from engaging in discourteous behavior (ie. arriving late, leaving early, reading the newspaper, sleeping etc.). Note: I am addicted to cell phone technology just like the rest of the world, but in class, I have a zero tolerance policy toward texting.

Attendance

This course covers a lot of ground in a very short period of time. Because we meet for at least 5 hours every Sunday, missing one class period is the equivalent of being absent for 2 weeks of a traditional 15-week semester (more on the overnight trips). **Because of the amount of contact hours and on-site field work built into our overnight trips, you must attend the full duration of both in order to be eligible to receive a passing grade for this course. If you miss a regular 5-hour class period (tardies count as absences) your overall course grade will be reduced by 1 full letter grade. If you miss 2 class periods, you will earn a failing grade for the course.** No one has ever fallen into this category, so don't be the first! Please note, I do not distinguish between excused and unexcused absences. If you might need to miss a class due to a religious holiday or campus business, please contact me BEFORE August 26 to try to work something out. Please note that due to the hyper-accelerated pace of this course, I reserve the right to not allow missed classes for these reasons. Out of fairness to students who make the sacrifice to come to class on time, missed work, including quizzes, cannot be made up.. Don't mess with me, because I love you but also totally mean business. ☺

Grading

Your grade for this course will be calculated as follows:

Close Reading Essay 1 (4-5 pages): 20%

Close Reading Essay 2 (4-5 pages): 20%

Final Essay (5-6 pages): 30%

Weekly Quizzes, Discussion Posts, and other Homework Assignments: 30%

A (94-100) A- (90-93) B+ (87-89) B (84-86) B- (80-83) C+ (77-79); C (74-76); C- (70-73); D+ (66-69); D (64-66); D- (60-63) F (59 and below)